

IN CONTEXT

Nineteenth-century nationalism

Smetana supported the National Revival movement that promoted Czech identity through language and art. Its adherents opposed the Germanization that had taken place under the Hapsburgs and Franz Josef I, the Austrian emperor and overlord of eastern European principalities and dukedoms. He was also the German-speaking king of Bohemia, center of Czech culture since medieval times but a vassal state since the Hapsburg victory at the Battle of White Mountain in 1620. King of Jerusalem, grand vaivode of the Voivodeship of Serbia, and ruler of more than 40 other cities or countries—Franz Josef's diverse titles and roles indicate why the move to preserve national identity was so pervasive in Europe at this time.



AUSTRIAN EMPEROR FRANZ JOSEF I IN UNIFORM

Bedřich Smetana was born in Litomyšl, Bohemia, on March 2, 1824. His father made a good living as a master brewer and played violin in his free time. Musically gifted, young Bedřich